

A PRACTICAL GUIDE

How to Build an AI Chief of Staff

By Russ Perry – Founder & CEO, Design Pickle

TOTAL ONGOING COST

~\$20/mo

Claude Pro. That's it.

"You're not automating tasks. You're replacing a role. The inbox, the phone, the morning briefing – these are jobs. Give them to an AI and get your time back."

THE STACK

3 tools.
One integrated system.

THE RUNTIME

Hermes Agent

The operating system your AI lives inside. Connects to email, calendar, phone, and custom commands. Runs 24/7 on your machine.

hermes-agent.nousresearch.com – free

THE BRAIN

Claude Pro (Anthropic)

Powers every decision your COS makes. Reads context, drafts in your voice, prioritizes what matters.

claude.ai – ~\$20/mo

THE VOICE

Bland.ai

Gives your COS a dedicated phone number. Screens inbound calls, handles scheduling, makes outbound calls on your behalf.

bland.ai – usage-based

BUILD THESE FIRST

The 3 highest-leverage things to deploy.

1 Email Triage

A 3-tier sort that runs every 30 minutes. Tier 1 gets flagged for your attention. Tier 2 is held. Tier 3 is archived. You only touch what matters.

SAVES 1–2 HRS/DAY

2 Morning Brief

Every morning, a personalized summary hits your phone. Today's meetings, top priorities, and the one thing that actually needs your decision.

REPLACES THE MORNING SCROLL

3 Voice Agent

A dedicated phone number your COS answers. Screens callers, collects info, books meetings directly into your calendar.

REPLACES A VIRTUAL RECEPTIONIST

"You're not automating tasks.
You're replacing a role."

Most people use AI to do things faster. The real unlock is using it to own an entire function – inbox management, call screening, relationship intel – so you never have to touch it again. That's a Chief of Staff, not a productivity hack.

REAL-WORLD PROOF

"I just scheduled your carpet cleaning with what I assume was your AI assistant... that was extremely cool and I would like to learn more about how you created your assistant."

– Jayden, Coconut Cleaning (texted Russ after booking with Pin, his AI COS)

WANT TO BUILD THIS WITH ME?

AI Chief of Staff – Live Course, May 2026

4 live sessions (May 5, 10, 11, 17 · 7–9 PM MST). You build your own system start-to-finish.

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